English Week 4: the empty town (written)

Ember · AQA English Language Paper 1, Question 2 format · about 20 minutes Date: _____

Skill: Quote, effect, So What. Short quotes. Say what the words make us picture or feel, explain *how*, then say what that tells us about the place or the people.

[8 marks]

Part A (about 12 minutes). Look in detail at this extract:

> The road into the town was empty. Weeds pushed up through the cracks in the tarmac, and a vending machine still glowed outside a shuttered shop, humming to nobody. Washing hung on a balcony, stiff and faded, as if the family had stepped out for a moment years ago. Somewhere a gate banged in the wind, again and again, like someone knocking who knew no one would answer. The silence was so thick it seemed to press against their ears.

How does the writer use language here to describe the empty town?
You could include the writer's choice of: • words and phrases • language features and techniques • sentence forms.

Part B: the same question, your book (about 8 minutes)

Find the part of *Tsunami Girl* where Yuki and Taka go into the zone. Copy two short quotes that describe the place.

Quote 1: “_____”

Quote 2: “_____”

Question: How does the writer use language to describe the zone?

Self-check (5 min)

□ Part A covers at least three different quotes.

□ Each quote is a few words, and each has an effect and a **how**.

□ At least one point reaches a So What: what the town comes to stand for.

□ Part B uses real quotes from *Tsunami Girl*, copied exactly.

□ Reflection: which quote was hardest to explain, and why?

How AQA marks Paper 1, Question 2 (8 marks)

- **Level 4 (7–8): perceptive, detailed.** Analyses the effects of the writer's choices of language; selects a range of judicious textual detail; makes sophisticated and accurate use of subject terminology.
- **Level 3 (5–6): clear, relevant.** Explains clearly the effects of the writer's choices of language; selects a range of relevant textual detail; makes clear and accurate use of subject terminology.
- **Level 2 (3–4): some, attempts.** Attempts to comment on the effect of language; selects some appropriate textual detail; makes some use of subject terminology, mainly appropriately.
- **Level 1 (1–2): simple, limited.** Offers simple comment on the effect of language; selects simple references or textual details; makes simple use of subject terminology, not always appropriately.

Ideas for Part A: the glowing, humming machine (life carrying on with no one there); 'stiff and faded' washing and 'as if… a moment' (lives interrupted); the simile of the knocking gate (loneliness, no one returning); 'thick' and 'press' (silence made solid); the short first sentence (blunt, empty). My level: _____

Practice passage written for Ember. Question format and level descriptors from AQA GCSE English Language 8700 Paper 1, Question 2, used for private practice.